

Tawny frogmouth

With its speckled and streaked gray and brown feathers, the tawny frogmouth is well camouflaged, against tree bark during the day. At night, it glides down from its perch to pounce on beetles, centipedes, frogs, and mice on the woodland floor. It snaps up insects from among the fallen leaves with its huge, wide bill. The tuft of stiff feathers at the base of the bill acts like a cat's whiskers, helping the bird find its way or sense food in the dark.



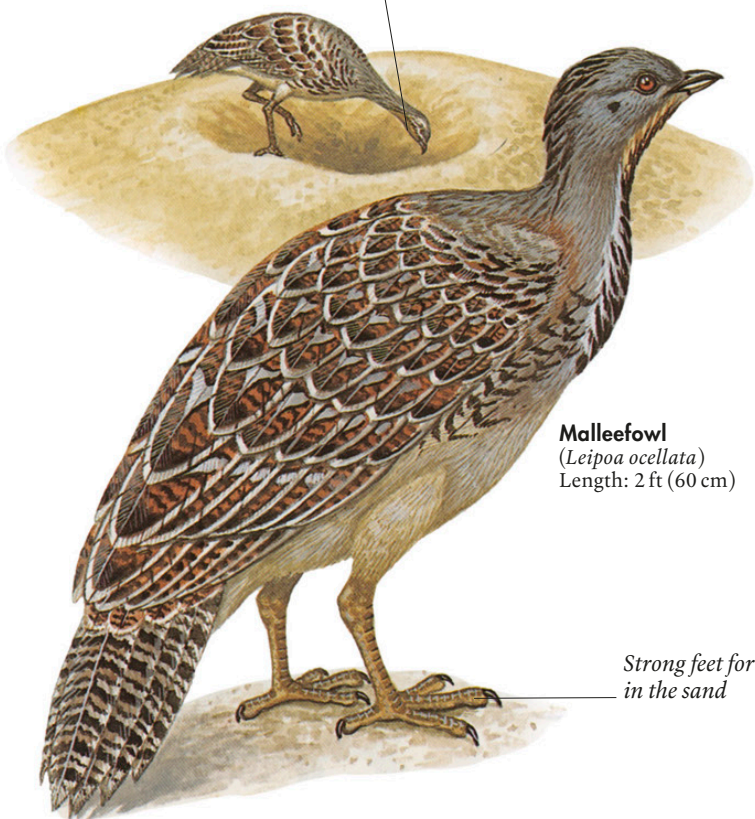
Tawny frogmouth
(*Podargus strigoides*)
Length: 1 ft 9 in (53 cm)

The frogmouth looks like a dead branch when it keeps very still in this stiff, upright position.

Malleefowl

The malleefowl builds a huge nest mound of wet leaves and twigs covered with sand. The female lays her eggs in the middle of the mound. As the leaves and twigs rot, they give off heat and this keeps the eggs warm. The male keeps a constant check on the temperature by prodding it with his bill and makes sure it is always about 93°F (34°C). He piles on more sand to make the mound warmer or opens up the mound to cool it down if necessary. When the chicks hatch, they dig their own way out.

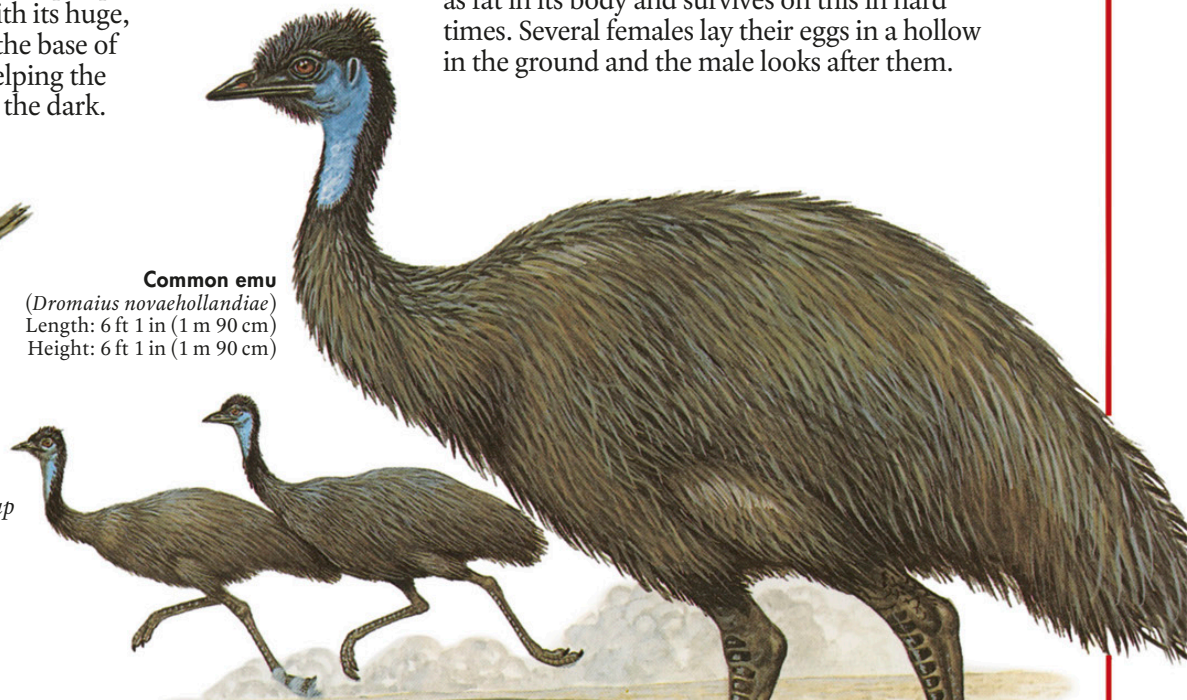
A male tests the temperature of the nest mound with his bill.



Malleefowl
(*Leipoa ocellata*)
Length: 2 ft (60 cm)

Strong feet for digging in the sand

Common emu
(*Dromaius novaehollandiae*)
Length: 6 ft 1 in (1 m 90 cm)
Height: 6 ft 1 in (1 m 90 cm)



The emu can run at up to 30 mph (48 kph) to escape from danger.

Common emus are related to ostriches, but they have three toes on each foot, whereas ostriches only have two.

This bird is named after the male's two outer tail feathers, which are shaped like a Greek musical instrument called a lyre.



Superb lyrebird

The male superb lyrebird dances and sings on mounds of soil to attract females for mating and to drive away rival males. He fans out his long tail and arches it forward over his head to form a shimmering silvery curtain. His body is almost hidden underneath the towering tail. The female builds a nest and looks after the single egg on her own until the young bird leaves the nest at about seven weeks old.

Superb lyrebird
(*Menura novaehollandiae*)
Length: male (including tail) up to 3 ft 3 in (1 m); female 2 ft 8 in (80 cm)

Long, powerful legs